

AY25 PROGRAM ASSESSMENT REPORT

v2026.1

Tracking Data

CIM code (e.g., ME-CM)	MLA-LND1 and MLA=LND2
Program Name	Master of Landscape Architecture + Urbanism
Assessment Year	2025
Program Assessment Coordinator	Prof. Ron Henderson
Year of Current Assessment Plan	2025
No Assessment This Year per Plan	☐
LO(s) Assessed	LO #1
Presented at program authority meeting date: <i>Please attach minutes</i>	09/26/2025

Methodology

The final submittal for LA543, Comprehensive Landscape Architecture Studio (Fall 2024) is selected as the assessment artifacts. The graduate bulletin description of the course states: The integration of local ecologies, projected use, and the performance of ephemeral, semi-permanent, and permanent site interventions into cohesive and resilient design proposals for varied urban sites. Introduction to a wide range of site-specific design standards including the Americans with Disabilities Act and barrier-free regulations.

Learning Object (LO) #1: Students will be able to

1. demonstrate ability to assess and analyze the physical, biotic, climatic, and cultural context of a project,
2. comprehensively synthesize objective and subjective analysis,
3. evaluate the suitability of a program to multiple sites
4. prioritize site based on program, and
5. communicate the criteria and methodologies used in evaluation.

Each criterion was scored across these five skills for 13 students, 6 of which serve as artifacts below.

The studio artifacts are a collective of analytical research sites compiled into two volumes of publications (270 pages total) that received a national American Society of Landscape Architecture Honor Award for Student Collaboration and was the subject of a public exhibition for which each student fulfilled their individual contribution to the work of the whole. The work was completed in collaboration between Illinois Institute of Technology and University of Tokyo. Only Illinois Institute of Technology students are evaluated by our university faculty.

Results

D. Does not meet expectations

M. Meets expectations

P. Proficient

1. demonstrate ability to assess and analyze the physical, biotic, climatic, and cultural context of a project,

Artifact 1: Omotesando Dori: P

Artifact 2: Kokyo Gaien: P

Artifact 3: Otemachi Forest: P

Artifact 4: Azabudai Hills: P

Artifact 5: Kenroku-en: P

Artifact 6: D.T. Suzuki Museum: P

2. comprehensively synthesize objective and subjective analysis

Artifact 1: Omotesando Dori: P

Artifact 2: Kokyo Gaien: P

Artifact 3: Otemachi Forest: P

Artifact 4: Azabudai Hills: P

Artifact 5: Kenroku-en: P

Artifact 6: D.T. Suzuki Museum: P

3. evaluate the suitability of a program to multiple sites

Artifact 1: Omotesando Dori: M

Artifact 2: Kokyo Gaien: M

Artifact 3: Otemachi Forest: M

Artifact 4: Azabudai Hills: M

Artifact 5: Kenroku-en: M

Artifact 6: D.T. Suzuki Museum: M

4. prioritize site based on program

Artifact 1: Omotesando Dori: P

Artifact 2: Kokyo Gaien: P

Artifact 3: Otemachi Forest: P

Artifact 4: Azabudai Hills: P

Artifact 5: Kenroku-en: P

Artifact 6: D.T. Suzuki Museum: P

5. communicate the criteria and methodologies used in evaluation

Artifact 1: Omotesando Dori: P

Artifact 2: Kokyo Gaien: P

Artifact 3: Otemachi Forest: P

Artifact 4: Azabudai Hills: P

Artifact 5: Kenroku-en: P

Student Collaboration

HONOR AWARD

TREES ALIVE! Techniques, Details, Traditions

Illinois Institute of Technology
and University of Tokyo

This unique program brought graduate and undergraduate students in architecture and landscape architecture together to explore the morphological, technical, and cultural aspects of tree planting and maintenance. For this trans-Pacific research exchange between the Illinois Institute of Technology and the University of Tokyo, students visited research sites in the United States and Japan, including notable urban landscapes such as Ōtemachi Forest in Tokyo and Bryant Park in New York. At each site, students documented the various tree-planting techniques and technologies in use, from pavement and soil types to horticultural practices and cultural expressions. American students learned about Japanese gardeners' use of *hoozue* (tree crutches) and *komorebi*, a word that describes the light that filters through a tree's branches and the resulting shadow patterns. The students' observations and original drawings were cataloged in a pair of booklets totaling 270 pages, a compendium of arboricultural knowledge spanning continents and cultures.

—
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2025 ASLA
STUDENT
AWARDS

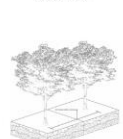


Artifact samples

OMOTESANDO DORI

SHIBUYA, TOKYO, JAPAN

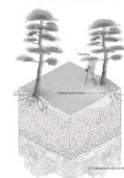
Omotesando Dori is a wide, tree-lined street in Shibuya, Tokyo, Japan. It is known for its large, mature trees and modern architecture. The street is a major thoroughfare and is home to many shops, restaurants, and offices. The trees are a mix of deciduous and evergreen species, and they provide a canopy of shade over the street.



KOKYO GAEN

CHITOSE, TOKYO, JAPAN

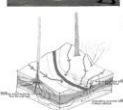
Kokyo Gaen is a large, open park in Chitose, Tokyo, Japan. It is known for its vast green lawn and many trees. The park is a popular destination for families and groups, and it offers a peaceful escape from the city. The trees are mostly deciduous, and they provide a canopy of shade over the lawn.



OTEMACHI FOREST

CHITOSE, TOKYO, JAPAN

Otemachi Forest is a large, open park in Chitose, Tokyo, Japan. It is known for its vast green lawn and many trees. The park is a popular destination for families and groups, and it offers a peaceful escape from the city. The trees are mostly deciduous, and they provide a canopy of shade over the lawn.



AZABUDAI HILLS

CHITOSE, TOKYO, JAPAN

Azabudai Hills is a large, open park in Chitose, Tokyo, Japan. It is known for its vast green lawn and many trees. The park is a popular destination for families and groups, and it offers a peaceful escape from the city. The trees are mostly deciduous, and they provide a canopy of shade over the lawn.





Description of findings

Summarize the discussion that occurred within the program authority when this was presented. Provide a short narrative interpreting the findings. Are there any areas of concern?

The collective approach in this studio has evolved to reflect more progressive, compassionate, and equity-driven principles. This shift moves away from traditional hierarchical and purely quantitative metrics toward a more holistic evaluation framework. Our pedagogy and collaborative efforts, both internally and with external partners, prioritize fostering meaningful, long-lasting relationships. We emphasize 'Collective Achievement', where success is measured by the progress of the group-as-a-whole. This approach values shared growth over individual accomplishments that may be subjected to subjective interpretation.

The ongoing discussions on the collective approach are concerned with institutional and accreditation pressures which are not oriented toward this collective approach but toward legacy models of individual achievement that is isolated from the responsibilities of engaging directly with partners and research outside the university.

Continuous Improvement, CI, plans

The purpose of assessment is to improve the quality of our educational programs. The most important part of the assessment cycle is how we use the data to improve our programs. Examine the data provided above describing student achievement, consider the root cause of any deficits, and if areas for possible improvement emerge, describe plans to achieve this improvement.

Prior CI plan impact

Also, please refer to the previous assessment report for the LOs assessed. Were any CI plans recommended? Were they implemented? Did the plans work (were improvements seen in this cycle)?

☒ no previous CI plans available

This cycle's CI plan

Describe any CI plans developed from this cycle's data, with

- *Specific curricular or instructional changes in response to this assessment data,*
- *A timeline for implementation,*
- *As well a description of who will participate in and manage these plans*

☐ *After consideration and presentation to the program authority, no CI plans are recommended.*

This studio was enriched with external funding that supported international travel. This global research was particularly successful, not surprisingly, in the first criterion, “demonstrate ability to assess and analyze the physical, biotic, climatic, and cultural context of a project.” In subsequent years, where international travel may not occur, the investigation and experience of global cultures will be lessened. How, then, can the course sustain the sense of global landscape systems and human cultures through which techniques, details, and traditions are expressed?

Criterion 3, “evaluate the suitability of a program to multiple sites,” was only modestly tested in this year of the course so this criteria will be more purposefully integrated into the next course offering.

Criteria 2, 4, and 5 need to be sustained in subsequent course offerings.

The timeline for this implementation will be the next offering of this course and will be coordinated with the three full-time faculty in the Master of Landscape Architecture + Urbanism program in collaboration with the Assistant Dean of Academic Affairs.